



A Symphony of Flavors

Mediterranean and Middle Eastern Spice Essentials

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EPICUREAN FLOW



A FIELD GUIDE TO NINE ESSENTIAL FLAVORS

Inside this collection

01	Sumac	03	06	Freekeh	23
	A tart, citrus-bright finishing spice			Ancient green wheat with a smoky, nutty character	
02	Saffron	07	07	Baharat	27
	Delicate threads with unmistakable color and aroma			A versatile blend at the heart of Middle Eastern cooking	
03	Iranian Barberries	11	08	Za'atar	32
	The jewel-like Persian berry known as zereshk			Herbal, nutty and tangy in equal measure	
04	Ras el Hanout	15	09	Harissa	36
	A complex North African blend with warm, floral depth			A bold North African chile paste with smoky heat	
05	Fenugreek	19			
	A bittersweet seed with a maple-like aroma				

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Select any profile above to move directly to that section.

SPICE PROFILE

Sumac

A tart, citrus-bright finishing spice



MEDITERRANEAN | MIDDLE EASTERN | NORTH AFRICAN



Sumac

A tart, citrus-bright finishing spice

Sumac

What it brings to the kitchen

Sumac is made from dried, ground berries of shrubs native to the Mediterranean and parts of the Middle East. Its deep crimson color and clean acidity brighten food without adding liquid.

FLAVOR PROFILE

Tart, fruity and lightly tannic, with a lemon-like lift and a dry finish.

CULINARY ROLE

Use it late in cooking or at the table, where its color and fresh acidity stay vivid.

BEST PAIRINGS

Tomato, cucumber, onion, parsley, eggplant, chicken, lamb, yogurt, lentils and flatbread.

CHEF'S TIP

Finish grilled vegetables with sumac, olive oil and a pinch of salt just before serving.

Working with Sumac

Four reliable ways to use it

- 1 Season salads and dips after the final taste adjustment.
- 2 Stir into yogurt, labneh or tahini for a quick tangy sauce.
- 3 Add to marinades for chicken, fish or lamb, then reserve a little for finishing.
- 4 Sprinkle over rice, couscous, roasted vegetables or eggs.

BUYING GUIDE

Look for a deep burgundy powder with a fresh, fruity aroma. Avoid dull brown sumac or blends padded with excessive salt.

STORAGE

Keep tightly sealed, away from heat and direct light. For the brightest flavor, buy in modest quantities.

COMMON MISTAKE

Heavy cooking can flatten sumac's aroma. Add most of it near the end.

Best form: coarse ground berries | Best moment: finishing | Character: tart and bright

SPICE 02

Saffron

Delicate threads with
unmistakable color and aroma

MEDITERRANEAN

MIDDLE EASTERN

NORTH AFRICAN





Saffron

Delicate threads with unmistakable color and aroma

Saffron

A concise profile

Saffron consists of the dried stigmas of *Crocus sativus*. Each flower yields only a few threads, which explains both its price and the care with which it should be used.

TASTE

Honeyed, floral and gently earthy, with a subtle hay-like bitterness.

ROLE

A small amount perfumes rice, broths, sauces, breads and desserts while adding a golden hue.

PAIR

Rice, seafood, chicken, tomato, citrus, almond, pistachio, cardamom and rose.

CHEF'S TIP

Crush the threads lightly, bloom them in warm water or stock for 10 to 15 minutes, then add both liquid and threads.

Working with Saffron

Four reliable ways to use it

- 1 Bloom before use so the color and aroma disperse evenly.
- 2 Add the infusion to rice, soups, stews, sauces or custards.
- 3 Use a light hand; more saffron does not always create a more elegant result.
- 4 For rice, reserve a little infused liquid to streak over the finished grains.

BUYING GUIDE

Choose dry, fragrant, uniformly red threads. Powder is harder to assess and loses aroma more quickly.

STORAGE

Seal away from light, air and moisture. A small opaque container is ideal.

COMMON MISTAKE

Do not scorch saffron directly in a hot pan; its delicate aroma can turn harsh.

Best form: whole threads | Best technique: blooming | Character: floral and luxurious



03 / SPICE PROFILE

Iranian Barberries

The jewel-like Persian berry known as zereshk

MEDITERRANEAN | MIDDLE EASTERN | NORTH AFRICAN



Iranian Barberries

The jewel-like Persian berry known as zereshk

Iranian Barberries

Iranian barberries, or zereshk, are small dried berries prized in Persian cooking for their vivid color and sharp sweet-sour flavor. They provide contrast in rich rice dishes, braises and salads.

Flavor and aroma

Brightly tart with a delicate fruitiness; brief cooking softens the sharp edge.

Best pairings

Saffron rice, chicken, lamb, caramelized onion, pistachio, almond, herbs and orange peel.

CULINARY ROLE

Use as a colorful accent rather than a dominant ingredient.

CHEF'S TIP

Rinse and drain the berries, then warm them very briefly with butter and a touch of sugar. Stop before they darken.

Working with Iranian Barberries

Four reliable ways to use it

- 1 Scatter through saffron rice or spoon over the finished dish.
- 2 Fold into pilafs, grain salads and herb-forward stuffings.
- 3 Balance their tartness with slowly cooked onion or a small amount of sugar.
- 4 Add near the end so the berries retain shape and color.

BUYING GUIDE

Choose berries that are red, dry and separate, not dusty, grey or clumped.

STORAGE

Refrigerate or freeze in a tightly sealed container, especially in warm or humid climates.

COMMON MISTAKE

Barberries scorch quickly. Use low heat and a short cooking time.

Also called: zerezhk | **Best moment:** final assembly | **Character:** tart and jewel-bright

SPICE PROFILE

Ras el Hanout

A complex North African blend with warm, floral depth



MEDITERRANEAN | MIDDLE EASTERN | NORTH AFRICAN



Ras el Hanout

A complex North African blend with warm, floral depth

Ras el Hanout

What it brings to the kitchen

Ras el Hanout is a North African spice blend whose name suggests the best selection a spice merchant has to offer. There is no single fixed formula; each blend reflects its maker, region and intended use.

FLAVOR PROFILE

Warm, aromatic and layered, often balancing pepper, sweet spice, earthiness and floral notes.

CULINARY ROLE

It builds depth in slow-cooked dishes and gives quick marinades a distinctly North African character.

BEST PAIRINGS

Lamb, chicken, beef, chickpeas, carrots, squash, couscous, dried fruit and preserved lemon.

CHEF'S TIP

Toast the blend for only a few seconds in oil before adding liquid. Stop as soon as the aroma opens.

Working with Ras el Hanout

Four reliable ways to use it

- 1 Rub onto meat or vegetables with oil and salt before roasting.
- 2 Stir into tagines, braises, soups and tomato-based sauces.
- 3 Use sparingly in couscous or rice so the blend supports rather than masks the dish.
- 4 Combine with yogurt, lemon and garlic for a fast marinade.

BUYING GUIDE

Smell before buying when possible. A good blend should be vivid and balanced, not dominated by stale cinnamon or dustiness.

STORAGE

Keep airtight and date the jar. Complex ground blends fade faster than whole spices.

COMMON MISTAKE

Recipes cannot assume every Ras el Hanout tastes the same. Taste the blend first and adjust gradually.

Style: merchant or house blend | **Best use:** layered savory dishes | **Character:** warm and complex

SPICE 05

Fenugreek

A bittersweet seed with a maple-like aroma

MEDITERRANEAN

MIDDLE EASTERN

NORTH AFRICAN





Fenugreek

A bittersweet seed with a maple-like aroma

Fenugreek

A concise profile

Fenugreek is used as seed, ground spice and dried or fresh leaf. The seeds are firm and aromatic, with a distinctive bittersweet character that becomes rounder when handled carefully.

TASTE

Bittersweet, nutty and earthy, with an aroma often compared with maple or caramel.

ROLE

A supporting spice that adds body and depth to blends, sauces, pickles and slow-cooked dishes.

PAIR

Lentils, tomato, potato, spinach, chicken, lamb, cumin, coriander, mustard seed and chile.

CHEF'S TIP

Toast seeds gently until fragrant, not dark. Fenugreek turns aggressively bitter when scorched.

Working with Fenugreek

Four reliable ways to use it

- 1 Toast whole seeds briefly before grinding or adding to a tempering.
- 2 Use ground fenugreek in small amounts in spice blends and sauces.
- 3 Crush dried fenugreek leaves between the palms and add near the end of cooking.
- 4 Soak whole seeds when a softer texture is wanted in pickles or braises.

Forms: seed, ground and leaf | **Best technique:** gentle toasting | **Character:** bittersweet

BUYING GUIDE

Whole seeds keep their character longer. Dried leaves should smell sweet, green and distinctive.

STORAGE

Store seeds and leaves separately in airtight containers away from light.

COMMON MISTAKE

Too much fenugreek can dominate a dish. Begin with a small quantity and build.



06 / SPICE PROFILE

Freekeh

Ancient green wheat with a smoky, nutty character

MEDITERRANEAN | MIDDLE EASTERN | NORTH AFRICAN



Freekeh

Ancient green wheat with a smoky, nutty character

Freekeh

Freekeh is young green wheat that is roasted, dried and rubbed to remove its husk. The process creates a pleasantly smoky grain with a firm, chewy texture.

Flavor and aroma

Nutty, toasted and gently smoky, with enough character to stand up to bold herbs and spices.

Best pairings

Chicken, lamb, chickpeas, tomato, cucumber, parsley, mint, lemon, yogurt and toasted nuts.

CULINARY ROLE

Use it as the base of a pilaf, salad, stuffing or hearty soup.

CHEF'S TIP

Cook freekeh in well-seasoned stock, then rest it covered before fluffing. The grains absorb flavor as they settle.

Working with Freekeh

Four reliable ways to use it

- 1 Rinse and check the grain before cooking.
- 2 Simmer in water or stock until tender but still pleasantly chewy.
- 3 Spread on a tray to cool before using in salads.
- 4 Stir into soups near the beginning so the grain has time to soften.

Form: whole or cracked green wheat |
Texture: chewy | **Character:** smoky and nutty

BUYING GUIDE

Cracked freekeh cooks faster; whole freekeh has a firmer bite. Choose according to the dish and follow the package timing.

STORAGE

Keep dry grain airtight in a cool cupboard. Refrigerate cooked freekeh promptly and use according to normal cooked-grain storage guidance.

COMMON MISTAKE

Do not cook only by the clock. Grain size varies, so taste for texture before draining.

SPICE PROFILE

Baharat

A versatile blend at the heart of Middle Eastern cooking



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Baharat

A versatile blend at the heart of Middle Eastern cooking

Baharat

What it brings to the kitchen

Baharat simply means spices in Arabic, and the blend varies across regions and households. Most versions combine pepper and earthy seeds with measured amounts of warm, sweet spice.

FLAVOR PROFILE

Warm, savory and aromatic, with gentle sweetness rather than overt heat.

CULINARY ROLE

An all-purpose blend for meats, rice, vegetables, soups and slow-cooked sauces.

BEST PAIRINGS

Beef, lamb, chicken, tomato, eggplant, lentils, rice, onion, pine nuts and dried fruit.

CHEF'S TIP

Use Baharat early enough to season the dish, then add a small fresh pinch at the end if the aroma needs lifting.

Working with Baharat

Four reliable ways to use it

- 1 Mix with salt and oil for a dry rub or wet marinade.
- 2 Bloom briefly in oil before building a soup, stew or tomato sauce.
- 3 Season rice, bulgur or lentils a little at a time.
- 4 Blend into minced meat for kofta, meatballs or stuffed vegetables.

BUYING GUIDE

Choose a blend with a clear peppery-spiced aroma. Compare ingredients because regional styles can differ widely.

STORAGE

Keep airtight, cool and dark. Replace when the aroma becomes faint or flat.

COMMON MISTAKE

Do not assume Baharat contains salt or chile. Read the label and season those elements separately.

Style: regional blend | Best role: everyday seasoning | Character: warm and savory

Build a balanced Baharat

Baharat is not a fixed recipe. This flexible starting point creates a peppery, earthy blend with measured warmth. Adjust it to suit the dish and the regional style you want to evoke.

FOUNDATION

2 parts black pepper
2 parts cumin
2 parts coriander

WARMTH

1 part cinnamon
1 part paprika
1/2 part cardamom

ACCENT

1/4 part cloves
1/4 part nutmeg
Optional pinch of
allspice

METHOD

- Combine freshly ground spices and whisk until evenly distributed.
- Taste the blend in warm oil or on a small piece of bread before seasoning a full dish.
- Label and date the jar, then adjust the next batch from your notes.

Chef's note: The goal is balance. No single sweet spice should dominate the blend.

SPICE 08

Za'atar

Herbal, nutty and tangy in equal measure

MEDITERRANEAN

MIDDLE EASTERN

NORTH AFRICAN





Za'atar

Herbal, nutty and tangy in equal measure

Za'atar

A concise profile

Za'atar can refer to an aromatic herb as well as the familiar regional blend of dried herbs, sesame, sumac and salt. Proportions vary, giving each blend its own balance of fragrance, nuttiness and acidity.

TASTE

Herbal and savory, with toasted sesame richness and a bright sumac finish.

ROLE

A finishing blend, bread topping and quick seasoning for vegetables, cheese and proteins.

PAIR

Flatbread, olive oil, labneh, feta, tomato, cucumber, eggplant, eggs, chicken and lemon.

CHEF'S TIP

For manakish-style flatbread, mix Za'atar with enough olive oil to form a loose paste that spreads without soaking the dough.

Working with Za'atar

Four reliable ways to use it

- 1 Sprinkle over labneh, hummus, eggs or sliced tomatoes.
- 2 Mix with olive oil for bread, marinades or a simple dip.
- 3 Finish roasted vegetables or grilled chicken after cooking.
- 4 Fold into breadcrumbs or savory pastry fillings.

BUYING GUIDE

Look for a fresh herbal aroma, crisp sesame seeds and visible sumac. Check the salt level before seasoning the dish.

STORAGE

Keep airtight and away from heat. Sesame-rich blends can lose freshness, so buy quantities you will use.

COMMON MISTAKE

High heat can dull the herbs and scorch the sesame. Reserve some blend for finishing.

Core notes: herb, sesame and sumac | **Best moment:** finishing | **Character:** savory and tangy



09 / SPICE PROFILE

Harissa

A bold North African chile paste with smoky heat

MEDITERRANEAN | MIDDLE EASTERN | NORTH AFRICAN



Harissa

A bold North African chile paste with smoky heat

Harissa

Harissa is a North African chile preparation made with peppers, garlic, oil and spices such as caraway, coriander and cumin. It may be sold as a paste, sauce or dry seasoning, and heat levels vary considerably.

Flavor and aroma

Peppery, savory and aromatic, ranging from gently warm to intensely hot.

Best pairings

Lamb, chicken, fish, chickpeas, carrot, tomato, squash, couscous, yogurt and preserved lemon.

CULINARY ROLE

Use it as a condiment, marinade base or flavor foundation for soups, stews and roasted foods.

CHEF'S TIP

Loosen harissa with olive oil, lemon juice or yogurt before brushing it onto food. This spreads the flavor more evenly.

Working with Harissa

Four reliable ways to use it

- 1 Serve alongside grilled meats, seafood, eggs or roasted vegetables.
- 2 Whisk into marinades and dressings, then taste before adding extra salt.
- 3 Stir into soups, stews, sauces or couscous for controlled heat.
- 4 Mix with yogurt or tahini for a milder dip or sandwich spread.

BUYING GUIDE

Check the ingredient list, salt and heat level. Choose paste for depth and dry harissa when a moisture-free rub is useful.

STORAGE

Refrigerate opened paste and follow the producer's directions. Use a clean spoon and keep the surface covered.

COMMON MISTAKE

Adding a large spoonful before tasting can overwhelm a dish. Build the heat gradually.

Forms: paste, sauce or dry blend | **Best role:** condiment and base | **Character:** smoky and hot